

Why do so many pro-AI people like to deflect the blame so much when the environmental issue is brought up?

Posted by u/FadingHeaven • 0 points • 41 comments

To start this is not about when an anti says "You're destroying the environment by using AI!" then a pro brings up other forms of online recreation that have the same or greater environmental impact. I think that's a valid criticism cause it begs the question of why one should be called out but not the other.

I'm talking about when someone says that the environmental impact of these data centres is high so we should do something about it. There is no hypocrisy there. It's just a factual statement and a call for a solution. It doesn't make much sense to say "What about the meat industry?" One industry being worse doesn't excuse what another industry does.

And before you start, I'm not talking about everyone. Only people who actually make these arguments which I've seen multiple times on this sub.

Comments

u/Mataric • 1 points • 2025-08-21 10:48 UTC

The environmental concerns are massively overstated, and are just an attack vector that ignorant people use to hate on something they know very little about, using facts and data that they've mostly made up.

For example, the 'water usage' of prompting chatGPT 40 times can be offset by turning your shower off a single second earlier. If you've ever had a 5 minute shower.. that's 12,000 chatGPT prompts. That's more than most people who use AI regularly will use in years and years.

It was assumed to be 3 watt-hours of electricity. Newer estimates are putting it at a tenth of that, at 0.3 watt-hours. An average electric shower where I am is 9 kilowatt-hours.

The social media post you just made to complain about people dismissing the environmental concerns is likely far worse for the environment than the AI they're raising these concerns over..

That's insane. It's disingenuous and uninformed.

u/FadingHeaven • 0 points • 2025-08-21 15:08 UTC

Overstated doesn't mean non-existent. This is assuming that you're actually addressing my central point in the second paragraph about how people deflect environmental damage when people are asking for solutions.

When I was researching this in the past, there was no comparison to Reddit posts or tweets. Though it's highly unlikely a text based post would have a higher energy or water usage than someone sending a similar text based prompt and a computer having to analyze that post and make its own output based on it. If I included an image then maybe. But you've gotta actually source your arguments when they're that specific. But damn is it impossible to find anything about Reddit data centres or energy usage cause all that comes up are Reddit posts.

u/Mataric • 1 points • 2025-08-21 15:33 UTC

Sure, it's not non-existent. No where did I state anything of the sorts, so please don't try to twist my point into something it's not.

My point is that it is practically non-existent in comparison.

You fundamentally don't understand what is going on with each of those processes. To put them both really simply..

For a chatGPT message and response, a message is sent to the server, it is stored on your account part of the database, the server does 0.1 second of math, then a response is sent back. There's also likely some tracking, analytic and training stuff that they'll do where they'll later read the database entry in the server again.

For your reddit post, your message is sent to the server, and it is stored on their database.

That database is then repeatedly queried and a bunch of math is done for analytics. Depending on those analytics, the message is sent out to a bunch of people. Each time those people view it, interact with it, or comment on it, a message is sent back to the server and that is used to update the database entry. Every time someone else is now fed your message in their feed and they click it, the additional information tagged onto it by other people is also going to get fed through to them. For this post, it's 38 more entries tied into it in the form of comments at the time of writing. That's the basic 'on the surface' stuff.

Then we can look at the additional things that happen with social media reddit comments.. Your message and the comments in the database are tracked. They are measured with math and used for analytics to figure out what Advertisements to link alongside them. Those messages are also often sent through to the AIs that reddit uses, and the AIs they train with your comments. The 'algorithm' will also do a bunch of math to figure out WHO to feed the post to.

Finally, a ton of web trawlers and crappy clickbait sites will view your comments on reddit. As a bit of a side angle - if it's popular enough, people will rewrite it slightly and quote comments from reddit then host them on another webpage to try and get their own ad revenue.

When you complain about datacentres, AI is not the issue. AI is a tiny fraction of the problem. Yes, it exists and is a part of these datacentres footprints, but it's the equivalent of standing in front of a football stadium floodlight and complaining about the energy you're 'wasting' by sticking an LED into a lemon.

u/ifandbut • 1 points • 2025-08-21 08:43 UTC

Driving my car to work for one trip uses more energy and produces more pollution than months of using AI for anything.

Sorry, but **scale** is important.

Every week I install a multi-kilowatt robot that will run about 24/7 for the next 10-20 years. That one robot alone will do more "damage" to the environment than a life time of AI gens.

If you really care about the environment, the most straightforward thing you can do is become vegan and only eat environmentally friendly foods (just cause it is vegan doesn't mean it is environmentally friendly).

u/FadingHeaven • 1 points • 2025-08-21 15:02 UTC

Yes and people that actually care about the environment so want people to use electric cars, the grid to be based on renewables and for driving to be less of a necessity. So that's not even a case where anyone is being hypocritical. Data centre usage is a case of hypocrisy cause I've yet to see a single person criticized for watching Netflix or YouTube at 4k.

Plus this only addresses the first argument which I've already agreed with not the second one which is the point I'm actually making.

u/Dersemonia • 1 points • 2025-08-21 08:42 UTC

Because using the environmental impact of data center against AI art, when I am using a local model on my pc, is a stupid point.

Especially while ignoring all the other services they use that rely on data centers, but the problem seems to be only when they are used for AI

u/FadingHeaven • 1 points • 2025-08-21 14:59 UTC

Most people don't run it on a local model on their computer though. I also addressed that first part in my first paragraph. The point I'm making is in the second.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-08-21 06:20 UTC

[removed]

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-08-21 06:20 UTC

In an effort to discourage brigading, we do not allow linking to other subreddits or users. We kindly ask that you screenshot the content that you wish to share, while being sure to censor private information, and then repost.

Private information includes names, recognizable profile pictures, social media usernames, other subreddits, and URLs. Failure to do this will result in your post being removed by the Mod team and possible further action.

I am a bot, and this action was performed automatically. Please [contact the moderators of this subreddit](/message/compose/?to=r/aiwars) if you have any questions or concerns.

u/Scam_Altman • 1 points • 2025-08-21 04:49 UTC

The Hypocrisy of Selective Environmental Outrage

The common dismissal of comparing AI's environmental impact to animal agriculture as a "tu quoque" fallacy is a strategic misdirection. It is not a logical fallacy to point out a profound inconsistency in the application of ethical principles. To express vehement concern about the resource consumption of AI models while actively defending or participating in the vastly more destructive system of industrial animal agriculture is not a fallacy—it is a textbook example of moral hypocrisy and cognitive dissonance.

This argument is an appeal to proportionality. It demands that our ethical concerns be calibrated to the scale of empirical evidence, not to which industry implicates our personal comforts.

1. The Objective Disparity in Environmental Impact

The data reveals an overwhelming difference in scale between the two sectors. Focusing on AI's footprint while consuming animal products is a misallocation of concern so severe it negates the credibility of the critique.

- Greenhouse Gas Emissions:

- The global dairy industry alone accounts for 3.4% of global GHG emissions

(<http://www.fao.org/3/i3437e/i3437e.pdf>).

- The entire livestock sector is responsible for at least 14.5% of all anthropogenic GHG emissions (<http://www.fao.org/3/i3437e/i3437e.pdf>), a figure larger than the exhaust from every plane, train, ship, and automobile on the planet combined.

- In contrast, the entire Information and Communication Technology (ICT) sector is estimated to be responsible for 1.8% to 3.9% of global emissions

(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2542435120305627>). AI is a fractional subset of this.

- Water Consumption:

- The water cost of a ChatGPT query is negligible. The production of animal products is the most water-intensive activity on Earth.

- Producing 1 kg of beef requires approximately 15,400 liters of water on average

(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0959652617322189>).

- A quarter-pound burger (0.113 kg) therefore requires roughly 1,740 liters of water. Complaining about the fractional water use of AI while consuming this product is logically incoherent.

- Land Use and Biodiversity Loss:

- 77% of global agricultural land is used for livestock grazing or growing its feed, despite providing only 18% of the world's calories (<https://science.sciencemag.org/content/360/6392/987>).

- Animal agriculture is the leading driver of deforestation and species extinction, yet this tangible, ongoing ecocide is often ignored in favor of abstract fears about AI's future potential for harm.

2. The Psychology of the "Meat Paradox"

This selective outrage is a documented psychological phenomenon known as the "meat paradox"—the mental conflict between caring about animals/the environment and eating them (<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S006526011630012X>).

To resolve this dissonance, people employ defense mechanisms:

- Willful Ignorance: Actively avoiding information about factory farms and environmental data.

- Dissociation: Using terms like "beef" and "pork" instead of "cow" and "pig."

- Moral Licensing: Performing concern over a less personal issue (AI) to subconsciously "license" the continued, more convenient unethical behavior (eating meat).

Complaining about AI allows a person to perform an identity of environmental concern ("Look how worried I am!") without addressing the inconvenient, culturally entrenched problem on their plate. It is hypocrisy designed to protect one's self-image.

3. Documented Human Mortality: A Comparison of Harms

The immediate, tangible harms are not equivalent.

- AI: Documented direct fatalities are currently minimal. The primary concerns are related to bias, error, and long-term societal impacts.
- Animal Agriculture: The harms are vast, current, and lethal.
- Antimicrobial Resistance (AMR): The overuse of antibiotics in factory farming is a primary driver of superbugs. It is estimated that AMR causes over 1.2 million deaths globally per year ([https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736\(21\)02724-0/fulltext](https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736(21)02724-0/fulltext)), a crisis to which animal agriculture is a major contributor.
- Air Pollution: Emissions from agriculture are a significant source of deadly particulate matter (PM2.5).

Expressing greater fear of AI's speculative risks while contributing to an industry that is a documented primary vector for a global health crisis that kills over a million people annually is a catastrophic misallocation of concern.

4. The Hypocrisy of Defending the "Personal Choice"

A common retort is that diet is a "personal choice," while AI is an external, corporate-imposed technology. This is a fallacy.

- AI's Potential for Good: AI is a tool being deployed to optimize renewable energy grids, model climate change impacts, and develop precision agriculture techniques that can reduce the environmental footprint of farming.
- The Illusion of Choice: Defending the "personal choice" to eat meat ignores the fact that this choice has devastating public consequences: immense public health costs from pollution and AMR, government subsidies, and catastrophic loss of biodiversity. The personal choice imposes a cost on everyone.

Therefore, criticizing AI—a tool with demonstrable sustainability applications—while defending the "personal choice" to support an industry that is a leading cause of environmental degradation is the height of hypocrisy. It prioritizes the defense of one's palate over the logical consistency of one's ethics.

Conclusion

The environmental costs of AI are real and demand mitigation. This argument does not grant tech companies a free pass.

However, to passionately critique the fractional impact of AI while financially supporting and personally participating in the vastly larger, empirically documented catastrophe of industrial animal agriculture is the definition of hypocrisy.

Pointing out this extreme disparity is not a "whataboutism" fallacy. It is a data-driven demand for

intellectual honesty. It challenges the cognitive dissonance that allows a fractional problem to eclipse a primary one because the primary one is delicious. Effective environmentalism requires addressing all significant contributors, starting with the largest ones, not just the ones that don't require us to change our own behavior.

u/FadingHeaven • 1 points • 2025-08-21 14:58 UTC

I apologize, but I'm not going to read all of this because based on your introduction it seems to be addressing my first point where I already addressed that selective environmental outrage is hypocritical and a valid point to rebut.

u/Scam_Altman • 1 points • 2025-08-21 19:30 UTC

>I apologize, but I'm not going to read all of this because based on your introduction it seems to be addressing my first point where I already addressed that selective environmental outrage is hypocritical and a valid point to rebut.

Sounds like your a scumbag who knows you lost the argument before it started. I directly answered your question. Focussing on shiny new technology to avoid meaningful environmental change is a form of "climate delay discourse". Datacenters are a drop in the bucket environmentally, and its a scientific fact that people engage in this kind of nonsense to give themselves a moral license to act destructively. It may be an objective fact that my faucet is leaking and needs to be fixed, but don't act like you have people's best interests in mind when you try to fix the faucet as a broken pipe floods the basement.

>I'm talking about when someone says that the environmental impact of these data centres is high so we should do something about it. There is no hypocrisy there. It's just a factual statement and a call for a solution. It doesn't make much sense to say "What about the meat industry?" One industry being worse doesn't excuse what another industry does.

u/techaaron • 2 points • 2025-08-21 04:46 UTC

Apparently they studied this and using AI which takes microseconds of compute is actually a lot more efficient than clicking away at a laptop for hours trying to get the same output.

It makes more sense of course AI is much more efficient than a meat puppet driving a computer around.

u/SgathTriallair • 2 points • 2025-08-21 04:05 UTC

It's not a factual statement. AI is not particularly damaging to the environment.

u/FadingHeaven • 1 points • 2025-08-21 14:55 UTC

It is though. Just comparing it to other things doesn't mean the damage is nothing just because other data centres are worse. Especially since there are plans to build significantly more of them. I don't know if it's slowed down or not but we already having [power consumption doubling every 100 days](<https://spj.science.org/doi/10.34133/icomputing.0006>) for specifically AI. If all AI data centres were powered on renewables then this issue would be overblown, except they're not. They're [increasing demand for natural gas plants]([https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2024-09-16/us-natural-gas-power-plants-just-keep-coming-to-meet-ai-ev-electricity-demand?](https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2024-09-16/us-natural-gas-power-plants-just-keep-coming-to-meet-ai-ev-electricity-demand?utm_source=website&utm_medium=share&utm_campaign=twitter?sref=pFpevH9K)
[utm_source=website&utm_medium=share&utm_campaign=twitter?sref=pFpevH9K](https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2024-09-16/us-natural-gas-power-plants-just-keep-coming-to-meet-ai-ev-electricity-demand?utm_source=website&utm_medium=share&utm_campaign=twitter?sref=pFpevH9K)). This is a

very bad thing that needs to be addressed now. You can't just build a plant for your data centre and then close it down in two years. The power is gonna continue being used. You can't just kick the can down the road until AI has the same power usage as YouTube. [Renewables are only at 27%](<https://www.iea.org/reports/energy-and-ai/energy-supply-for-ai>)of the demand and nuclear is at 15%. Coal is 30% which is terrible and at 26% which is bad, but not as bad. Renewables are increasing which is good, but the centres are also increasing growth in both coal and natural gas which is the real problem for the reason I stated earlier.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-08-21 03:39 UTC

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